

# Book Reviews

*THE IMMIGRATION AND SETTLEMENT OF ASIAN INDIANS IN PHOENIX, ARIZONA, 1965-2011: ETHNIC PRIDE VS. RACIAL DISCRIMINATION IN THE SUBURBS.* By Emily Skop. Lewiston, New York: The Edwin Mellen Press. 2012. Pp.315

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The most extraordinary feature of the Asian Indian settlement pattern in the United States in the recent past has been suburbanization. In the early 1980s, 55 percent of the Indian population resided in the suburbs, and by 2000 this group ranked highest among the more highly suburbanized foreign-born minorities in the United States. This population shift to the suburbs has occurred mainly because activities that were formerly concentrated in central cities have now relocated to suburbia, most notably the high-tech manufacturing and quaternary occupations that employ many Indian immigrants who are highly skilled professionals with considerable educational accomplishments. By virtue of Indian immigrants' socioeconomic status, they prefer and can afford to live close to their suburban workplaces, which in turn has resulted in the sprouting of many Indian businesses in the suburbs as well. But 'Little Indias' – areas where the majority of people (and/or businesses) of Indian origin are to be found in traditional immigrant gateways like Chicago, New York and Los Angeles – have not yet developed in the newly emerging gateways of Indian settlement.

This growing pattern of settlement in metropolitan Phoenix – a newly emerging gateway for Indian migrants – and the articulation of various place-making strategies by Indian migrants and their midlevel organizations in (re)constructing 'Indian' racial and ethnic identities is the central theme of Emily Skop's book *The Immigration and Settlement of Asian Indians in Phoenix, Arizona, 1965-2011: Ethnic Pride vs. Racial Discrimination in the Suburbs*. The new and ongoing dialogue between studies of new immigrant destinations and those of traditional destinations is the focus of Skop's book, which addresses the complicated question of the geographical underpinnings of migration theories in the United States. Skop addresses the issue by displacing the sites of knowledge production to new destinations and suburbs. She underscores the need to develop a coherent sense of the field

as we move forward by 'exploring varying stories of urban migrant life' (p. 3) and, in doing so, to give greater attention to spatial variations.

After the preface, the book has a total of seven chapters. In Chapter 1, Skop explores two primary place-making strategies used by Indian migrants to construct their identity: (a) building permanent spaces as permanent sites for the display and cultivation of Indian heritage, and (b) making fleeting use of 'transitory spaces' that bring families together to celebrate their cultural and religious traditions. She goes on to explain that both of these strategies are important in the formation of Indians' racial and ethnic identity.

Next, Skop introduces the concept of 'visibility' and 'invisibility' of Indian migrant spaces and places, and how these Indian spaces and places are thought of by the native white population of Phoenix, who 'play a key role in the social construction and classification of ethnic groups and radicalized minorities' (p. 4). In this first chapter, the reader is also introduced to the situational matrix, a framework for examining the linkages between migrants, Indian community organizations, and local, national and international forces. The author argues that this conceptual framing of interaction between the scales has often been ignored in the literature and, hence, is a major contribution of her research on the formation of racial and ethnic identities. Consequently, urban spaces are not a passive backdrop but sites of power, prestige and privilege. Thus, locating the Indian migrants' place-making strategies and spaces, and also their function in identity formation, will add to the understanding of the Indian experience in the United States.

Chapter 2, 'Passage from India: Migration to the United States,' chronologically documents and discusses the numbers, diversity, geography and 'invisibility' of Indian migrants to the United States from 1800 to the present. It documents the sea changes in Indian migration to the United States since the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965, particularly in the trends and types of Indian immigrants and settlement patterns. The chapter especially highlights the suburbanization and 'invisibility' of the Indian migrant population. Skop considers both these features to be remarkable aspects of this migrant group. According to her, the primary cause of invisibility of Indian migrants in the United States is the regional diversity among the Indian migrants, which discourages solidarity. Reviewing the existing literature, the author proposes that their 'invisibility' could also be inferred as a 'racial strategy to avoid self-identification by skin color or race as much as possible' (p. 51). Indian migrants prefer the impression of the community as a 'model minority' rather than one involved in racial politics. Consequently, without the spatially bounding practices and boundaries that normally accompany the construction of race and ethnicity, further probing is necessary to find new insights into the resilience of race and ethnicity and the socio-spatial dialectics among suburban Indians.

Chapters 3, 4 and 5 are the most conceptually useful sections of the book. They use the situational matrix to examine the interactive and dynamic nature of Indian migrant settlement in Phoenix from the individual to the global level. In Chapter 3, Skop elaborates on the configuration of Indian residential and business settlement in Phoenix, which she reasons plays a crucial role in creating an invisible landscape. The Indian population in Phoenix is scattered, with the majority living in the newer suburbs within the North Phoenix and East Valley regions, which are predominantly white. Skop justifies that in contrast to traditional gateways like

New York, Los Angeles and Chicago, where 'migrant settlement patterns tend to overemphasize how ethnic ties and social networks channel individual migrants to the locations of friends and relatives' (p. 83), her research exposes other factors that play a determining role in migrant settlement in newly emerging gateways: strong job markets, diverse employment opportunities and relatively cheap housing costs.

In Chapters 4 and 5, the author highlights the existing tension between the role and functioning of permanent spaces – for example, the establishment of pan-ethnic organizations for identity formation of 'Indian-ness' versus the nature of midlevel organizations, which are regional, linguistic, less visible, transitory and personal. In both chapters, Skop focuses on the group dynamics, the role of leadership and the myriad place-making strategies employed by Indian migrants to (re)create an identity in the United States. As an illustration of permanent spaces of activity for Indian migrants, she points out that the Indo-American Cultural and Religious Center, the Hindu Temple of Arizona, and Indian restaurants and businesses in Phoenix attempt to bring together members of a complex and heterogeneous community: Indians from northern states who arrived in the 1960s and 1970s, recently arrived migrants from southern states of India and an increasing number of second-generation, US-born Indians. However, despite the genuine efforts of the leaders of the two organizations and local business owners to be inclusive in their social, economic and cultural endeavors, and to organize Indians as a single group, they are met with substantial resistance by linguistic-regional and religious subgroups who have significantly different lifestyles and customs. Hence, the creation of pan-Indian solidarity and a collective strategy for empowerment continues to be a challenge for this group of migrants.

In Chapter 5, Skop moves the discussion forward by underscoring how 'Indian-ness' is created by a set of divergent regional groups representing varying interests. Here, she introduces the concept of 'transitory' spaces as opposed to 'permanent' spaces as sites for constructing a sense of togetherness. She defines transitory spaces as traditional spaces of whiteness that are transformed into social and communal spaces that Indian migrants temporarily call their own. These spaces exist for a short time and then are returned to the customary whiteness without catching the attention of anyone. Examples of these spaces are movie theaters, public parks and schools, where parochial identity is maintained – by organizing communal activities, like kid-friendly picnics, screenings of regional films and celebrations of regional festivals – with the intent of undermining the all-encompassing and less meaningful vision of Indian-ness presented by permanent organizations. The author argues that in these transitory spaces, the Indian migrants can remain 'invisible' to anyone except themselves (p. 138) and that this is the predominant trend among the highly skilled Indian migrants. The chapter concludes with the unresolved question of how well these parochial associations perform as agents of socialization for US-born, second-generation Indians.

In Chapter 6, using numerous narratives from thirty in-depth interviews with Indian migrants, Skop discusses several factors that emerge as important in the process of creating an Indian identity at the individual level: socioeconomic status, life course functions and duties, parenthood, loyalty to regional associations and care giving responsibilities for aging parents. Therefore, shaped by the different experiences of migrants in Phoenix at the personal and societal levels,

five different ethnic identifications emerge on a continuum from most engaged to most dissatisfied: active ethnics, enduring ethnics, retiring ethnics, dissenting ethnics and stranded ethnics. The continuum serves to mark the complexity and contradiction of ethnic formation within the Indian migrant community. Hence, the phenomenon can be best explained from a 'constructionist' view of ethnic identity formation. The conclusion (Chapter 7) succinctly revisits the discussions of earlier chapters on how socioeconomic and migrant status, work as an expression of self, and concerns to remain 'invisible' and unmarked as a social group are important for ethnic and racial identity formation for suburban middle- and upper-class Indian migrants. Skop ends the book with a possible future research suggestion: comparing the experiences of new migrants to American society who seem to disappear within more prestigious spaces of whiteness with those less fortunate who settle in marginalized 'visible' spaces.

Overall, it is an intriguing book dealing with space and place-making strategies in the construction of identity, without belaboring the often repeated and 'stale' debates on migrant assimilation and cultural pluralism, which are inadequate for the distinctive characteristics of contemporary migrants. Besides, the book is a fascinating read about the experiences of technologically skilled and well-educated Indian migrants in a new immigrant destination, given that there have been extremely sharp negative turns in many new destinations' social institutions and political contexts of reception after 2005. The only major issue I had that I would suggest for future research is to look more systematically into the sustained transnational ties, practices and actions of technologically skilled and affluent Indian migrants in the construction of their identity in the United States. In other words, to explore how cross-border ties in various spheres of life and in various stages of the life course are dealt with in the 'local' contexts for (re)creating identity. This book contributes to the scholarship on new migrant destinations and can play a leading role in developing a thorough understanding of how identity formation works for migrants depending on when they arrive and where they settle.